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A Comparison of Marx's and Whitehead's Process Thought

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Abstract

Karl Marx and Alfred North Whitehead can both be considered process thinkers, viewing the world as a dynamic process rather than a static collection of things, with entities constantly being formed. They reject isolated, fixed worldviews, advocating for interconnected and evolving perspectives. Both integrate contemporary scientific advancements into their philosophies to promote societal progress, yet key differences exist. Marx's thought is rooted in material unity, social practice, and dialectical materialism, while Whitehead's focuses on processual reality, empiricism, and speculative generalization. Their scientific foundations diverge: Marx draws on cell theory, conservation of matter, and biological evolution, while Whitehead incorporates the theory of evolution, electromagnetism, relativity, and quantum mechanics. Moreover, Marx's theory champions proletarian liberation through communism, while Whitehead aims to foster a civilized society valuing truth, beauty, art, adventure, and peace.

Keywords

Marx – Whitehead – process – philosophy of organism – practical materialism

Generally, Karl Marx (1818–1883) could be considered a practical materialist, while Alfred North Whitehead (1861–1947) identified himself as a realist. Although they never had a personal encounter in history, Whitehead was familiar with Marx's work. And it is well recognized today that both of their conceptions of the world contains a great amount of ideas about process. Marx's process thought is extensively discussed in Yan Shunli's *Marx's Philosophical Process Theory* (2013), while Anne Fairchild Pomeroy's *Marx and Whitehead* (2004) compares the process philosophies of Marx and Whitehead in detail. Despite these contributions, systematic comparisons of their process thought – particularly their similarities and differences – are still lacking in academic literature.

This paper aims to address this gap by analyzing the similarities and differences between Marx's and Whitehead's process philosophies through the perspectives of cosmology, ontology, methodology, scientific basis, and ultimate goals. Both thinkers share the core belief that “the world is a process,” but their interpretations diverge significantly. For Marx, the process reflects the essential movement, change, and development of real-world entities. In contrast, Whitehead sees the process as fundamental reality itself, where the essence is becoming and transformation of actual entities.

By comparing these perspectives, this paper seeks to clarify the fundamental nature of process thought. On one hand, it enhances our deep understanding of Marx's historical materialism, highlighting the transformative impact of his philosophy on human thought. On the other, it deepens our understanding of the “process turn” in Western philosophy, as Liu (2012, p. 28) observes:

Only by truly understanding the significance of the change of Western philosophy from ancient times to modern times as a “process turn” of philosophical thinking mode, can we truly grasp the context and trend of the development of modern Western philosophy as a whole, and more deeply understand the great significance of the modern transformation of Western philosophy.

It is marked by Whitehead's shift from substance to process in his philosophy of organism. Moreover, this comparison underscores the relevance of process philosophy for addressing contemporary global challenges, particularly the ecological and environmental crises, and moving beyond the limitations of industrial civilization.

1 The World as a Process: Core Concepts in Marx's and Whitehead's Thought

Marx's philosophy is renowned for introducing historical materialism. Friedrich Engels famously noted that Marx made two groundbreaking discoveries: the materialist conception of history and the revelation of the surplus value in capitalism. Marx himself referred to his philosophical approach as "new materialism" or "practical materialism." Regardless of its label, Chinese academic circles generally agree that the concept of praxis or practice is central to Marxist philosophy. Unlike traditional Western philosophy, which often focuses on explaining the world, Marx's philosophy seeks not only to interpret reality but to change it through practice. His famous dictum, "Philosophers have only *interpreted* the world in various ways; the point is to *change* it" (Marx & Engels, 1975b/2010, p. 5, original emphasis), epitomizes this fundamental characteristic.

Whitehead, widely regarded as the founder of process philosophy, explicitly calls his system the "philosophy of organism" in *Process and Reality* (orig. 1929; Whitehead 1978, p. 3). He sought to distance his approach from the traditional Western schools of thought, including both materialist and idealist philosophies, as well as Cartesian dualism. His philosophy is a fully developed form of organicism, which emphasizes the interconnectedness and fluidity of all entities.

At their core, both Marx and Whitehead assert that the world is not static but a dynamic process of continuous motion and change. Let us compare their philosophies in more detail by applying the aforementioned perspectives.

1.1 *Cosmology*

Both thinkers agree that the world is inherently fluid and ever-changing. Marx, however, places special emphasis on the processes of movement, change, and development in the realms of nature, society, and human activity. In *Economic and Philosophical Manuscripts of 1844*, Marx highlights that humanity is part of nature and that the humanization of nature is an integral aspect of the same process. He famously writes, "Man *lives* on nature," meaning that "nature is his *body*, with which he must remain in continuous interchange if he is not to die" (Marx & Engels, 1975a/2010, p. 276, original emphasis). In *Theses on Feuerbach* (1888), Marx conceptualizes human activity as objective, practical activity, asserting that "the coincidence of the changing of circumstances and of human activity can be conceived and rationally understood only as

revolutionizing practice” (Marx & Engels, 1975b/2010, p. 7). He criticizes earlier materialists (such as Feuerbach) for treating objects, reality, and sensibility as passive entities, rather than recognizing them as active human processes driven by practice and history. Practice, for Marx, is the historical process of reality in action.

In *The German Ideology* (written 1845/1846), Marx emphasizes the importance of starting from “real, active men” and their tangible life processes to understand the development of ideological reflections, rather than beginning with abstract concepts or imagined ideas. He writes:

Not of setting out from what men say, imagine, conceive, nor from men as narrated, thought of, imagined, conceived, in order to arrive at men in the flesh; but setting out from real, active men, and on the basis of their real life-process demonstrating the development of the ideological reflexes and echoes of this life-process. The phantoms formed in the brains of men are also, necessarily, sublimates of their material life-process, which is empirically verifiable and bound to material premises. (Marx & Engels, 1975b/2010, p. 36)

Here, Marx underscores that ideological processes are rooted in material life and can only be understood in connection to real, verifiable human activity.

Engels, in *Ludwig Feuerbach and the End of Classical German Philosophy* (1886), further elaborates on Marx’s approach, stating that they recognized “the great basic thought that the world is not to be comprehended as a complex of ready-made *things*, but as a complex of *processes*” (Marx & Engels, 1990/2010, p. 384, original emphasis). For Marx, materialist dialectics reveal the transient nature of all things, showing that nothing is final or sacred, and that everything is in state of constant becoming and passing away. As Engels notes, the flaw in eighteenth-century materialism was its failure “to comprehend the world as a process, as matter undergoing uninterrupted historical development” (Marx & Engels, 1990/2010, p. 370).

Whitehead similarly posits that “the world is a process.” In *Process and Reality*, he states that “the actual world is a process, and the process is the becoming of actual entities” (1978, p. 22). Moreover, according to Whitehead, the concept of “process” was raised to the level of principle, and the so-called “principle of process” was clearly summarized for the first time in the history of human philosophical thought: “That *how* an actual entity *becomes* constitutes what that actual entity *is*; so that the two descriptions of an actual entity are not independent. Its ‘being’ is constituted by its ‘becoming.’ This is the

‘principle of process’” (1978, p. 23). The whole of *Process and Reality* is built on this core notion: reality is process, and process is reality.

Therefore, although Whitehead explicitly calls his philosophy “the philosophy of organism” in *Process and Reality* (1978, p. 1), numerous scholars recognize its philosophy by the name of “Philosophy of Process” because the fundamental thesis of *Process and Reality* can be formulated as “the world is a process.” Without understanding Whitehead’s “principle of process,” it is impossible to understand his realism. The great contribution of Whitehead to philosophy in general is his systematical demonstration of a “Philosophy of Process,” and as such, it is appropriate to refer today to Whitehead as a “philosopher of process.”

1.2 *Ontology*

From an ontological perspective, both Marx and Whitehead insist that actual entities are in a state of constant becoming, a process that never ceases. Marx views practice as the fundamental basis for understanding and interpreting reality, arguing that every actual thing in the world is involved in continuous movement, change, and development. For Marx, the process of actual entities – and by extension, the process of the world as a whole – is an empirical fact, primarily manifested through the socialization of nature and the naturalization of society. This integration occurs through human practice, which acts as a transformative mediator. Through practice, society imprints its purposes onto nature, turning nature into something that serves society’s needs, while nature, through practice, becomes an enduring factor in society, thus forming what Marx refers to as a “natural society.”

In this view, human practice is the foundation of the world’s existence, functioning as the real essence, or “noumenon,” of the human world. This dynamic, evolving ontology makes the human world an open system that continuously scales and develops in levels of complexity (Li, 1996, p. 5). As Marx writes, this is a “real, positive science” that expounds on the practical activity and development of human beings, based on their “actual, empirically perceptible process of development under definite conditions” (Marx & Engels, 1975b/2010, p. 37).

Whitehead, in contrast, grounds his philosophy of organism in process ontology to explain the becoming of actual entities, or “organisms.” He posits that, on a micro level, process refers to the becoming and transformation of “actual occasions,” the smallest units of the real world. These occasions reflect the creative advance of nature and the broader universe, expressed through ongoing emergence, disappearance, and object permanence of entities. Whitehead refers to this dynamic as the “principle of unrest” (1978, p. 32), emphasizing that the actual world manifests as a process because of the underlying force

of creativity, which drives the continual emergence and dissolution of actual entities, as well as larger, macro-level societal and universal structures.

Austrian process philosopher Roland Faber describes Whitehead's philosophy as an "organicism of processuality," recognizing the organic and dynamic nature of Whitehead's process thought, where creativity serves as the universal driving force behind the continuous unfolding of reality (Faber, 2023, p. 110). Thus, both Marx and Whitehead emphasize the dynamic, interconnected, and ever-evolving nature of the world, even if they approach it from distinct ontological frameworks.

1.3 *Methodology*

From a methodological perspective, both Marx and Whitehead emphasize the need to view actual entities and the world as interconnected and dynamic, rejecting static, isolated, or one-sided viewpoints. Marx's core methodological approach is materialist dialectics, which he developed by transforming Hegel's idealist dialectics through a materialist lens. Grounded in a scientific understanding of practice, Marx's dialectics reveal the fundamental nature of movement, change, and development in nature, society, and human thought and the basic laws that follow. He identified the interconnectedness and perpetual development of the world as an unalterable reality, governed by key dialectical laws: the law of the unity of opposites, the law of the transformation of quantity into quality and vice versa, and the law of negation of negation.

Whitehead's methodology is based on speculative generalization rooted in process-relational thinking, which I refer to as the "thorough empirical method." Scholar David R. Griffin described this approach as "panempiricism," while Chinese scholars often term it "generalized empiricism" (Yang & McDaniel, 2018, p. 25). In *Process and Reality* (1929) and *Modes of Thought* (1938), Whitehead advocates for understanding the world as a process of ongoing relations. He sees actual entities as continuously generated, with their essence determined by the relationships they form. These entities are interrelated and interdependent, constituting an organic, living whole. On a micro level, each actual entity or occasion is a "drop of experience," connected to and interacting with other entities.

Whitehead's speculative generalization abstracts the process of becoming from this reality, but he warns that such abstraction is always selective and partial. Generalization, though useful, remains an abstract category and cannot capture the full process of real-world generation. While theoretical precision is important, Whitehead cautions against mistaking abstract models for concrete reality, a mistake he calls the "fallacy of misplaced concreteness." This occurs when an abstraction is taken as the reality itself – akin to confusing a

map for the landscape it represents. As Whitehead famously asserts in *Process and Reality*, “philosophy is explanatory of abstraction, and not of concreteness” (1978, p. 20). Despite the inherent limitations of abstraction, philosophy can offer humanity valuable knowledge about reality by helping to clarify these conceptual frameworks (1978, p. 3).

1.4 *Scientific Basis*

Both Marx and Whitehead ground their philosophical thought in the latest natural scientific discoveries of their respective eras. For Marx, the scientific foundation of his philosophy was built upon three major nineteenth-century discoveries: cell theory, the law of conservation and transformation of energy, and the theory of biological evolution. In this regard, Engels offers a detailed explanation and investigation in *Ludwig Feuerbach and the End of German Classical Philosophy* (Marx & Engels 1990/2010, p. 386):

Thanks to these three great discoveries and the other immense advances in natural science, we have now arrived at the point where we can demonstrate the interconnection between the processes in nature not only in particular spheres but also the interconnection of these particular spheres as a whole, and so can present in an approximately systematic form a clear picture of the coherence in nature by means of the facts provided by empirical natural science itself.

These scientific breakthroughs provided the empirical basis for Marxist philosophy, a point widely accepted within Marxist scholarship. As Engels notes in *Dialectics of Nature* (1925), “With these three discoveries, the principal processes of nature are explained and ascribe to natural causes” (2018, p. 66).

Whitehead, as a mathematician and philosopher, on the other hand, drew from the scientific advancements of the early twentieth century, particularly James Clerk Maxwell’s electromagnetism, Albert Einstein’s theory of relativity, and Max Planck’s quantum mechanics. Like Marx, he also incorporated Charles Darwin’s theory of evolution into his philosophical framework. Whitehead explores these influences extensively in works such as *An Enquiry Concerning the Principles of Natural Knowledge* (1919), *The Concept of Nature* (1920), *Science and the Modern World* (1925), and *Process and Reality* (1929). These scientific ideas shaped his “philosophy of organism,” which played a key role in what some scholars have called the “process turn” in Western philosophy.

This shift marked a move away from static, substance-based metaphysics toward a focus on dynamic processes. Scholars such as Liu Fangtong and Lu Jierong (2014) have argued that Whitehead’s process philosophy contributed

to the broader intellectual trend of “the rise of process and the decline of substance” in twentieth-century Western thought, capturing the spirit of the era and fundamentally transforming the landscape of philosophical inquiry.

1.5 *Ultimate Goals*

Both Marx and Whitehead, as philosophers, pursued the advancement of human liberation and the progress of civilization. Marx’s ultimate aim was the complete emancipation of humanity by eradicating class oppression and exploitation, culminating in a communist society where the union of free individuals is the defining feature. His vision sought not just political or economic reform but the total transformation of society, ensuring the liberation of all people.

Whitehead envisioned a more nuanced and cultural goal: the creation of a civilized society founded on truth, beauty, art, adventure, and peace. In *Adventures of Ideas* (orig. 1933), he explicitly defines civilization as a state where these five values are embraced by its members: “A society whose members share the five qualities of truth, beauty, adventure, art, and peace is a civilized society” (Whitehead, 1967, p. 285). His philosophical project was less concerned with the material conditions of society and more focused on fostering an intellectual and moral culture that cultivates human potential and enriches the human experience.

1.6 *Summary*

To sum up, Marx and Whitehead are aligned in their fundamental belief that the world is a process, suggesting that, to some extent, these towering philosophers thought alike. However, this section has already hinted at significant differences in their thought. The next section will delve deeper into these differences and their implications, again drawing on our five analytical lenses but with the addition of social class.

2 **Process as Becoming or Development? Key Differences between Marx’s and Whitehead’s Process Thought**

The core difference between Marx’s and Whitehead’s process philosophies centers on whether the process is primarily about the *becoming* of actual entities (Whitehead) or their *development* from lower to higher forms (Marx). In simple terms, is process fundamentally about becoming or development?

Marx’s process thought is rooted in the concept of development. He posits that all actual entities and the entire world move from lower to higher stages,

from simple to complex. Although this development trajectory is often non-linear and fraught with challenges, Marx viewed it as inherently progressive. His philosophy emphasizes that the process of development follows the law of negation of negation, reflecting a wave-like or spiral progression that results in continual advancement. Marxism argues that the interconnectedness of actual entities is the driving force behind this eternal development. As Engels succinctly states in *Dialectics of Nature*, “interaction is the real ultimate cause of the development of things” (2018, p. 96).

In contrast, Whitehead’s process philosophy places greater emphasis on *becoming* rather than development. He views the process of actual entities as an ongoing transformation and creative advance, without necessarily implying progress toward a higher state. While Whitehead acknowledges that the universe may become more complex and diverse over time – summed up in the phrase “the many become one, and are increased by one” (1978, p. 21) – he does not assume that the future will be better than the present or the past. Human civilization, in his view, might stagnate or even regress, with some civilizations potentially perishing over time. This is why the concept of development rarely appears in Whitehead’s works. His focus is on the “creative advance of nature,” which involves constant transformation and an increase in diversity, but not necessarily growth in the traditional sense.

Some scholars have criticized Whitehead’s concept of process for lacking this dimension of progress. This critique holds merit, as Whitehead does not envision a guaranteed improvement in human civilization. Instead, he argues that the future of humanity depends largely on the values we choose and the ideas we practice. For Whitehead, intellectual and moral exploration – what he calls the “adventure of ideas” – is crucial for human progress. Without such bold ventures into new ideas and value-driven choices, human civilization risks stagnation or even regression. Whitehead warns that conformism can cause civilizations to falter or even reverse their course until they collapse. He thus emphasizes that “adventure [of ideas] is essential, namely, the search for new perfections” (1967, p. 258).

As such, Marx’s view stresses the developmental nature of the process, anchored in materialist dialectics and historical progression. Whitehead, however, offers a more fluid and uncertain vision of process as constant becoming, where progress depends on intellectual and moral choices rather than inevitable advancement.

2.1 *Cosmology*

As we’ve noted, Marx adhered firmly to the materialist worldview, emphasizing the material unity of the world. For him, process refers fundamentally to

the ongoing motion and development of the objective, real world, which is grounded in the objective reality of matter. However, the Marxist concept of matter moves beyond the old materialism's view of static, tangible substance. Instead, it encompasses the inherent objective reality of all things. Engels and Lenin both articulated this revised understanding of matter. As Engels notes in *Dialectics of Nature*, matter and motion are not seen or experienced by anyone, but only the various, actually existing material things and forms of motion: "Matter is nothing more but the totality of material things from which this concept is abstracted, and motion as such nothing but the totality of all sensuously perceptible forms of motion" (2018, p. 116). Thus, terms like "matter" and "motion" are simply abbreviations in which we comprehend many different perceptible things according to their common properties.

Whitehead's philosophy, by contrast, is an *organic* cosmology that sees fundamental reality itself as processual. His philosophy of organism aims to construct a coherent, logical, and necessary system of general ideas capable of interpreting every element of our experience. In other words, his philosophy provides "a condensed scheme of cosmological ideas" based on human experience, with the goal of elaborating an interconnected framework in which all specific topics are related (Whitehead, 1978, p. 3, xii). His view of the universe is one of organic interconnection, where the cosmos functions as a living system of interdependent processes. This approach distinguishes Whitehead's cosmology from traditional Western philosophies based on substantial materialism, offering a more fluid and holistic understanding of reality. In *Process and Reality*, Whitehead constructs a logical and internally consistent system that reframes our understanding of the world as a unified, dynamic organism.

2.2 *Ontology*

Ontologically, the process thought of Marx and Whitehead are rooted in different noumena: human practice for Marx and the becoming of actual entities (organisms) for Whitehead. Marx's philosophy, according to Lenin's party principle, is firmly situated within the materialist camp, distinct from the idealist tradition. However, Marx's materialism is not of the traditional, general kind; rather, as we mentioned earlier, it is a practical or historical materialism. This makes Marx's philosophy fundamentally different from earlier forms of materialism but also from dualism, agnosticism, skepticism, relativism, and idealist philosophies. For Marx, material reality is inseparable from human practice, which is the basis for understanding both the natural and social worlds.

Whitehead's process thought, on the other hand, is explicitly grounded in "actual occasions" or *experience* as its ontological basis. Unlike Marx, Whitehead rejects the notion of substantial materialism, considering it a product of the

fallacy of misplaced concreteness. Drawing from electromagnetism and quantum mechanics, he denies the existence of static, inert “substantial material.” In early works such as *The Concept of Nature*, Whitehead posits that the smallest constituent unit of reality is a dynamic “event-particle,” a form of being within a field that is extensive and temporal, yet not a solid, inert substance.

In *Process and Reality*, Whitehead advances the concept of “actual entities” as the fundamental building blocks of reality. He states:

“Actual entities” – also termed “actual occasions” – are the final real things of which the world is made up. There is no going behind actual entities to find anything more real [...]. The final facts are, all alike, actual entities; and these actual entities are drops of experience, complex and interdependent. (Whitehead, 1978, p. 18)

Whitehead's ontology is thus atomistic in character. In his view, even microscopic entities such as quanta are “drops of experience.” Whitehead critiques and negates the traditional notion of substance as it was understood in Cartesian and Aristotelian philosophy, further rejecting the material substance model inherited from Newtonian mechanics. This marks a sharp departure from materialist and substantialist ontologies in favor of a dynamic, relational understanding of being.

2.3 *Methodology*

As we've noted, Marx clearly insisted on a form of materialist dialectics as the methodology of his philosophical system. He once emphasized that his dialectical method not only differed from Hegel's but fundamentally opposed it. For Hegel, the process of thought, which he elevated to an independent subject called “the Idea,” is the creator of all real things, with material reality being merely a manifestation of this thought process. Marx, on the contrary, argued that ideas are nothing more than material phenomena transplanted into the human brain and transformed in thought. Engels further highlighted the significance of Marx's dialectical method: “The working out of the method which underlies Marx's critique of political economy is, we think, a result hardly less significant than the basic materialist outlook” (Marx & Engels, 1980/2010, p. 475).

Materialist dialectics is revolutionary in nature because it recognizes not only the positive existence of things but also their inevitable negation and transformation. It understands all things in constant motion, in both their transient and enduring aspects. Therefore, dialectics does not hold any established form as sacred or permanent. By its very nature, it is *critical* and *revolutionary*, fundamentally questioning and challenging the status quo.

Whitehead, by contrast, relied on a methodology of speculative generalization rooted in process and relational analysis. In his works, Whitehead sought to move beyond static morphological analysis and factor analysis, advocating instead for understanding through processes and relationships. His speculative generalization extends beyond the empirical method and seeks philosophical insights that transcend the boundaries of scientific generalization (Yang & McDaniel, 2018, chap. 4).

In *Process and Reality*, Whitehead famously described his methodology with an analogy:

The true method of discovery is like the flight of an aeroplane. It starts from the ground of particular observation; and it makes a flight in the thin air of imaginative generalization; and it again lands for renewed observation rendered acute by rational interpretation. (Whitehead, 1978, p. 5)

This speculative approach, while expansive and imaginative, remains grounded in empirical observation. Whitehead maintained that philosophical inquiry must begin with concrete empirical data, just as in natural science. From this foundation, one can then generate abstract generalizations. However, the validity of these abstractions must be tested against experience in practice. Only through practical experience can the truth of philosophical generalizations be verified and affirmed. In this sense, Whitehead's methodology parallels the empirical rigor of natural sciences while reaching beyond it into the realm of speculative thought.

2.4 *Scientific Basis*

As we noted earlier, Marx's philosophy was deeply rooted in the major scientific breakthroughs. Engels highlighted the importance of mathematics and natural sciences in establishing a dialectical and materialist understanding of nature. Marx, proficient in mathematics, and Engels, who dedicated eight years to studying contemporary natural sciences, built a solid scientific foundation for the development of Marxist philosophy. Engels noted that the three key discoveries of the nineteenth century – cell theory, the law of the conservation of energy, and the theory of biological evolution – provided the empirical basis for the new philosophical system Marx had founded.

These scientific advancements marked a shift from the pre-eighteenth-century approach, where natural science was mainly concerned with collecting and categorizing material. By the nineteenth century, natural science had evolved into a discipline focused on understanding processes, development,

and interconnection. Engels likened Marx's discovery of the law of human history to Darwin's discovery of the law of organic development, demonstrating how Marx's philosophy bridged the gaps left by earlier natural philosophy, which often relied on speculative, imagined connections rather than real, observable interrelations (Marx & Engels, 1990/2010, p. 386). This solidified Marx's ability to uncover the true processes of development in both nature and human history.

Whitehead, in contrast, grounded his philosophy in the scientific advances of the twentieth century, particularly Darwin's theory of evolution, Maxwell's electromagnetism, Einstein's theory of relativity, and Planck's quantum mechanics. His philosophy of organism drew heavily on the principles of these discoveries. While a fellow at Trinity College in Cambridge, his thesis on the philosophical significance of Maxwell's electromagnetism challenged the Newtonian view by arguing that magnetism is an intrinsic property of objects, not the result of external forces as Newton had claimed (Whitehead, 1920).

The theory of relativity revolutionized the understanding of time and space, showing that they are inseparable from the motion of matter. Quantum mechanics, with its wave-particle duality and uncertainty principle, revealed that microscopic particles exist as dynamic events rather than static entities. These insights laid the groundwork for Whitehead's development of his event theory, extended continuum theory, prehension theory, and ultimately, his process metaphysics. His vision of the universe as an interconnected, evolving organism was shaped by these scientific ideas, and he incorporated them into a comprehensive metaphysical system that emphasizes process and relationality over static substance.

2.5 Social Class

As a corollary to our five primary analytical perspectives, it is worth introducing the lens of social class here, as both thinkers held fundamentally different views on this issue – or rather, it is fundamental to the thinking of one and absent in the philosophy of the other. Marx explicitly anchored his philosophy in the proletariat, positioning it as the class basis of his theory of society. The new philosophy he founded was devoted to the liberation of all humanity, particularly through the emancipation of the working class. Marx viewed the proletariat not only as a driving force for societal change but also as the class whose liberation would lead to the free and all-around development of all individuals. He famously stated, “As philosophy finds its *material* weapons in the proletariat, so the proletariat finds its *spiritual* weapons in philosophy.” For Marx, “The head of this emancipation is *philosophy*, its heart is the *proletariat*”

(Marx & Engels, 1975a/2010, both quotations from p. 187, original emphasis). Thus, his philosophical project was inseparable from the struggle for class liberation, grounded in the material realities of social and economic inequality.

In contrast, Whitehead's philosophy of organism reflects the influence of his bourgeois politics and class perspective. His philosophy is consciously or unconsciously rooted in the middle class of the developed Western world. As a result, Whitehead's thought tends to avoid discussions of class and class struggle, focusing instead on more abstract ideals of civilization. His work often engages with universal human concerns without addressing the specific material conditions of different social classes. This omission reveals the class limitations of some bourgeois scholars in Western societies, who, like Whitehead, tend to speak from a position of privilege that overlooks the structural inequalities shaping modern social life.

2.6 *Ultimate Goals*

In terms of ultimate pursuits, Marx's process thought is clearly committed to achieving the free and comprehensive development of all human beings. This goal represents the fundamental value pursued by Marxism and the defining feature of the communist society Marx envisioned. In *Manifesto of The Communist Party* (1848), Marx and Engels describe the ideal society in the following terms: "In the place of the old bourgeois society, with its classes and class antagonisms, we shall have an association, in which the free development of each is the condition for the free development of all" (Marx & Engels, 1976/2010, p. 506). Even within the communist society, Engels emphasized that it would not be a static endpoint for human development but rather a society of continuous growth and perfection. This idea reflects the core of Marxist process thought, which recognizes the ongoing nature of societal evolution.

Whitehead's process thought, in contrast, is centered on the continuous progress of human civilization and opposes rigidity and conservatism in any social order. He argues that when civilizations become stagnant or resistant to change, they risk becoming rigid and ultimately declining. Throughout history, some civilizations have flourished while others have disappeared due to this internal dynamic. Whitehead's pursuit is focused on the ideal of a developing, dynamic civilization, characterized by five core virtues: truth, beauty, art, adventure, and peace. He envisions a society that embodies these virtues, fostering a harmonious and vibrant civilization. A truly civilized individual, in Whitehead's view, is one who embodies these virtues.

However, Whitehead remains vague about how such an ideal society or the development of civilized individuals can be achieved within the capitalist system of his time. He provides no clear sociopolitical philosophy or practical

steps for realizing this vision. In contrast to Marx, who was both a theorist and a revolutionary deeply engaged in real-world sociopolitical change, Whitehead was more of an idealist and thinker. His work lacks the concrete revolutionary framework that Marx offers for transforming society. While Marx sought practical ways to reshape the world, Whitehead's contributions remain more philosophical, without direct guidance on how to implement his vision of a dynamic civilization.

3 Conclusions

Three broad conclusions can be drawn from the preceding analysis.

First, while both Marx and Whitehead are key figures in process thought, and both assert that the world is in some way inherently a process, their approaches are fundamentally distinct and should not be equated. Marx's process thought is rooted in the premise of the material unity of the world. Matter is not the substantive category of classical materialism but rather objective reality itself. This understanding underpins his view that universal connection and eternal development are core characteristics of materialist dialectics. Marx's philosophy asserts that everything is interconnected and in constant development, following a dialectical process of transformation and progress.

In contrast, Whitehead's process thought is premised on a rejection of the objective reality of solid matter. Rather, process is reality, and reality is process. His framework is heavily influenced by scientific advancements such as electromagnetism and quantum mechanics, and he interprets the world as a living organism in light of biological evolution. His philosophy seeks to explain the organic nature of processuality. Thus, while some, like Victor Lowe, have mistakenly labeled Whitehead's approach as "process materialism" (1990, p. 269), this misrepresents the essence of his thought. Whitehead's philosophical position was never truly materialist. He consistently criticized scientific materialism, such as classical notions in Cartesian dualism or the mechanical view of matter grounded in Newtonian physics, which he found inadequate for understanding the nature of reality.

Instead, Whitehead offers a vision of the world as an interconnected, living process, pushing the boundaries of scientific materialism toward an organic and relational interpretation of reality. However, we know that Marx also regarded the world as an organism and understood nature as an evolving, historical process. This leads us to a significant question: Which framework better captures the true nature of the world – Marx's vision of an objective, material, and real world governed by historical processes, or Whitehead's view of

the world as a dynamic, living organism in constant process? This question invites deeper reflection and exploration within philosophical inquiry to better understand the nature of reality and the processes that shape it.

Second, Marx's concept of process is inseparable from his philosophy of eternal development. For Marx, process thought inherently underpins the idea of development, laying a foundation for understanding the continuous evolution of the world. In his view, the world progresses in a spiral or wave-like motion, driven by dialectical laws such as the negation of negation. This dialectical progression offers a solid philosophical basis for humanity's pursuit of a better, more ideal society. Marx's emphasis on development connects deeply to his materialist understanding of history and society, where processes are not static but always moving toward a higher stage of evolution.

In contrast, Whitehead's process thought focuses on becoming and transformation, without an explicit emphasis on development, as found in Marx's framework. Whitehead's concept of process aligns more with the notion of change as a constant, rather than a teleological progression toward improvement. In this sense, his understanding of process bears similarities to the Chinese philosophical concept of "Yi" (易) from the classical text *The Book of Changes* (*Zhouyi*). As Cheng Zhongying explains in *Ontology of the Study of Changes*, the term "Yi" encompasses five key attributes: permanence (or non-change), change, simplicity, exchange, and harmonization (2020, pp. 14–46). Whitehead's idea of process seems to share these attributes, suggesting a closer alignment with the cyclic and relational patterns of classical Chinese thought than with Western teleological models of development.

Whitehead himself noted this affinity, observing that his philosophy of organism bears closer resemblance to certain strains of Indian and Chinese thought than to Western thought (1978, p. 7). This prompts an intriguing question: Can Whitehead's process philosophy be viewed as more aligned with the cosmological and philosophical traditions of the *Book of Changes*, Taoism, and Confucianism, which also emphasize harmony, transformation, and balance? This is an avenue of inquiry that merits further exploration and research.

Third, Whitehead's philosophy systematized process thinking from both ancient and modern traditions, ultimately constructing a metaphysical system centered on process. This is why his work is recognized as "process philosophy" in academic discourse. Today, many scholars who focus on environmental and ecological crises see Whitehead's philosophy of organism as a potential foundation for transcending industrial civilization and building a sustainable ecological civilization. His relational and organic approach offers a framework for rethinking human–nature relationships in an era of ecological crisis.

Thus, for Marxists, it is essential to approach Whitehead's process thought dialectically, critically assessing which aspects align with Marx's philosophy and which do not. Marx's materialist dialectics provide a scale for evaluating Whitehead's ideas, distinguishing between useful insights that can be inherited and integrated, and elements that must be discarded as incompatible with historical materialism. This is, in my opinion, the guiding principle that should shape any comparative study of Marx's and Whitehead's process philosophies.

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